

>> flexibility and posture

Genetics dictate how flexible you are and also your postural body type. Stiffness and over-flexibility both cause aches, pains, and difficulty in day-to-day activities. Explore your flexibility with these easy tests, and strive to find your best neutral posture.

Gravity has a greater impact upon our posture when we are upright in sitting or standing. If we give in to it, the “segments” of our body collapse (see below left). The result is that our muscles are out of balance and our joints are misaligned.

Stretching counterbalances this and helps you develop a good neutral posture. You start by using good form and working the muscles of the inner

unit (see p.14). This helps you stretch the chest and shorten the upper back muscles, open the lower back and engage the abs, as well as stretch the front of the hips and thighs, and the calves.

Practicing sitting and standing tall also solidifies your intent to push vertically upward against the force of gravity. The beauty of this formula is that it applies to all body types and levels of flexibility.



Gravity breaks us into unbalanced segments (far left). The head falls forward. The chest shortens and sinks, and the upper back rounds. The lower back tightens and collapses, and the abdomen protrudes. The front of the thighs and hips tighten, while the hip extensors slacken. Body weight lists back on the heels, shortening the calves.

The goal is to balance the segments and achieve neutral posture, with a straight line running from the head through the pelvis (left). Note especially how the weight of the heavy head is now balanced directly over the pelvis, which houses our center of gravity. This alignment puts the least amount of strain on the spine as well as on the other joints in the body.